

Feedback report #3



Setting Up Your Home in the UK

Welcome to the UK! Landing in the British countryside on Permanent Change of Station (PCS) orders is an incredible adventure, but setting up a home here comes with its own unique twist. From smaller floor plans and lack of built-in wardrobes to navigating military housing policies, getting your home up and running requires a distinct strategy.

Here is everything you need to know about housing inspections, temporary furniture, and sourcing your own pieces to turn your new UK house into a cozy home.

Navigating UK Housing Inspections

Whether you land an on-base house or decide to live "on the economy" in a local British village, inspections are a mandatory part of the process—but your specific status dictates the rules.

For Unaccompanied Housing (Dorms)

If you are arriving as unaccompanied personnel and moving into base dormitories, you must report to the Unaccompanied Housing (UH) Management Office on the next duty day following your arrival.

- **The Move-In Inspection:** An Airman Dorm Leader (ADL) or a civilian Dorm Manager will physically walk you through your room. Together, you will perform a thorough move-in inspection and check off an inventory of all allotted furnishings and supplies.
- **Your Responsibility:** You are expected to keep your room and any shared living spaces tidy and clean. While cleaning supplies are often provided free of charge, you are fully accountable for the furnishings. Any damage beyond normal fair wear and tear could result in personal liability, so note even the smallest scuffs during your initial inspection.

Active Duty and DoD Civilians: If you are *US Active Duty personnel*, you have a strict mandatory requirement to have your property inspected and cleared by the base housing office. If you are a DoD Civilian, the inspection requirement is optional.

- **Move-In (Initial) Inspection:** For everyone renting locally, the letting agent will conduct a move-in inspection. You will be handed an inventory and condition report. *Do not rush this.* Test every light switch, check the water pressure, note any damp spots, and photograph existing scuffs on walls or carpets to protect your security deposit.
- **Mid-Tenancy Landlord Inspections:** Be prepared for a different pace of renting than in the US. Many UK landlords and property managers legally write inspection clauses into the lease. It is standard practice for them to require a property inspection 3 months after the lease starts, followed by recurring inspections every 6 months thereafter to check on the upkeep of the property.

Sourcing Temporary Furniture & Essentials

Your Household Goods (HHG) shipment can take anywhere from a few weeks to a couple of months to cross the Atlantic. Fortunately, you don't have to camp out on a sleeping bag in an empty living room. The *Furnishings Management Office (FMO)* (sometimes called the Furnishing Management Section or FMS) is here to help.

- **The Furnishings Management Section (FMS):** The military provides Temporary Furniture Loaner Kits for up to **90 days after your arrival** (and 90 days before you PCS out). These kits include essentials like beds, a dining table and chairs, a sofa, chests of drawers, and coffee tables.

Note: You are responsible for bringing or purchasing your own sheets, pillows, cookware, and towels.

- **Temporary Kitchenware:** Don't worry about buying paper plates or cheap cookware. You can visit your base Military Readiness Center (Airman & Family Readiness Center) to borrow "Loan Locker" kits, which include vital everyday items like pots, pans, plates, and utensils.

Long-Term "Duration of Tour" Items

There are certain items FMO will loan you for the **entire duration** of your UK tour. This is incredibly useful because UK homes frequently lack features that are standard in the US:

1. **Major Appliances:** Do not ship your US washer, dryer, refrigerator, or stove! Standard UK electrical currents run at 220 volts and 50 Hz, meaning US appliances will not work. FMO will supply a refrigerator, stove, washer, and dryer for your home.
2. **Wardrobes:** Closet space is a luxury in traditional British homes—most bedrooms do not have built-in closets. FMO will issue up to two wardrobes per family member so you have a place to hang your uniforms and civilian clothes.
3. **Heavy-Duty Transformers:** To keep your small, dual-voltage, or 110V US electronics running without frying them, FMO can issue heavy-duty voltage transformers for your entire tour.

How to Book an FMS Delivery

To get your temporary furniture and major appliances delivered to your new home, you must submit your paperwork well in advance:

1. **Access the Forms:** FMS request packages can be found digitally via your base **SharePoint** (under *Housing Office/Documents/FMS/FMS Packages*) or directly on the **AF Connect App** (under *Housing/Furniture Management Section/New Arrivals*).
2. **Submit the Timeline:** Ensure you process your application at least **10 days prior** to your official move-in date to secure your delivery window. Standard requests usually take 5 to 7 duty days to process and deliver.
3. **Required Documents for Appliances:** If you are living off-base and requesting appliances (washer/dryer, stove, fridge), you must also submit a Landlord/Tenant statement signed by both you and your landlord/letting agent confirming that these appliances are not already provided by the property.
4. **Delivery Coordination:** Once paperwork is submitted, the FMS team (located at the FMO warehouse at neighboring **RAF Feltwell, Building 73**) will coordinate your delivery date.

Note: You or an authorized adult with a power of attorney must be physically present at the house during the entire delivery window.

Where to Buy Furniture in the UK

Before you start shopping, keep this critical detail in mind: *UK homes, doorways, and rooms are generally much smaller than those in the US*. If you have giant, bulky American-sized furniture (like a US King/California King bed), it might literally not fit through the front door or up the narrow staircases. It is often highly recommended to wait until you measure your UK home before buying large items.

Here are the best places to shop for furniture in the UK, depending on your style and budget:

On-Base Resources

- **The Base Exchange (BX):** Perfect for buying brand-new, UK-compatible electronics, home essentials, and select furniture items with the convenience of tax-free shopping and familiar US customer service.
- **The On-Base Thrift Store / Airman's Attic:** The fastest and cheapest way to buy furniture from other military families. You can easily find standalone wardrobes, UK-voltage lamps, and heavy-duty transformers from families preparing to PCS back to the States.

Retail Favorites

- [Dunelm](#): A massive favourite across the UK. Dunelm is a one-stop-shop that offers an incredible variety of affordable, stylish furniture sets, mattresses, bedding, and home decor items perfect for filling up a house quickly without breaking the bank.
- [TK Maxx](#) (and **Homesense**): While famous for clothing, select larger TK Maxx stores feature massive, dedicated home and furniture sections. The **TK Maxx in Cambridge**, for example, is highly popular among local expats for its unique, high-quality accent chairs, coffee tables, and global decor gems at heavily discounted prices.

- [John Lewis](#): The gold standard for high-quality British furniture, excellent customer service, and long warranties. Ideal for investment pieces like sofas.
- [IKEA](#): The go-to for affordable, modular storage solutions—essential since British bedrooms rarely feature built-in closets or wardrobes.
- [Habitat](#): Known for its contemporary, stylish British designs, Habitat offers beautiful mid-range sofas, tables, and lighting options. You can find standalone stores or browse their collections online.
- [Next Home](#): A highly popular UK high-street retailer that offers fantastic quality mid-range furniture, specifically tailored to modern UK home dimensions.

British Charity Shops

- **Furniture-Specific Charity Stores:** Do not overlook British "charity shops." Unlike standard thrift stores, major organizations like the **British Heart Foundation**, **Emmaus**, and **Sue Ryder** run massive, furniture-only warehouses in nearby towns (like Bury St Edmunds, Ipswich, and Cambridge). They offer heavily discounted, gently used wardrobes, dining sets, and sofas that often fit perfectly into classic English layouts.

Final Pro-Tip for Newcomers

Do not buy everything at once! Live in your space for a couple of weeks with your FMS loaner furniture to see how the natural light moves through the rooms and how you utilize the layout. This prevents you from buying pieces that crowd your beautifully historic new UK home.

Don't underestimate the power of the local military community! Because families are constantly arriving and departing, the local **community Facebook "yard sale" pages** are goldmines. You can often find high-quality, gently-used UK-sized furniture, curtains, and 220V electronics from departing families at a fraction of retail cost. Click [here](#) to access helpful Facebook groups.